



Anil Seth

Managing Content Security in Drupal 7

'Workbench' helps to define who should do what to manage content on a site.

In any organisation, there is the inevitable issue of who should manage content on the website. There are concerns about the authenticity of the information, and accountability for the content displayed on the site. In many cases, organisations do not mind delaying making information available since they are very averse to inappropriate content showing up on their site.

By default, you can control access by defining roles. Those in a particular role may have access rights to a content type. This is generally too restrictive an option. The same content type may be used across the organisation, but rights may depend on the actual content. As expected, there are a number of modules available for Drupal 7 that address certain aspects of this concern. The module that you may find very useful is Workbench (<http://drupal.org/project/workbench>). It consists of four additional modules. We will discuss the access and moderation modules, which are especially useful and relevant in most instances.

Access

Typically, the first area of concern is to allow only certain people to manage sub-sections in a site. For example, the marketing department should be responsible for any sales- and marketing-related content. Content related to each product can be managed by the corresponding product manager—that is, a hierarchical control is desirable for the management of the website.

The Workbench Access module provides two mechanisms for controlling access. The first way is by using a menu. Menus are hierarchical. So, access rights can be given to people for each node of a menu. A person with rights to the *Products* node will have rights to the individual products under that node.

This set-up is very simple to understand, and seems easy to implement. However, it requires the menu to be modelled on the ownership hierarchy of the content. In some instances, content managed by the marketing department may need to be a part of the *Corporate* (or some other) node. This complicates the management of access rights. It is better to identify particular content with a label, and manage the content accordingly, regardless of where it may be displayed

on the site. To meet this need, the alternative taxonomy-based mechanism offered by Workbench Access is a far better option. You define a hierarchical taxonomy, very much like a menu, using the *Structure => Taxonomy* option in the administrative menu. You need to worry only about the parent-child relationship in the definition of the taxonomy, and not about the type of content each node represents.

Once the taxonomy is created, you can enable the Workbench Access module and associate the newly created taxonomy with it. Each term in the taxonomy becomes a *Section* to be managed by Workbench Access. You need to make sure the content types you want to be managed by access control are enabled.

The next step is to associate editors with each section—that is, you add those users for each section, who are permitted access to the corresponding section. Now, when users try to add content, they can only do so in a section for which they have rights and nothing more.

Moderation

It is better to try one module at a time, for better understanding of the flow. Hence, disable the Workbench Access module and uninstall it. Now, enable the Workbench Moderation module, then enable the content types that need to be moderated, by selecting *Structure => Content Types* in the administration menu. Then check the *Create New Revision* and *Enable Moderation of Revisions* options. This is done in the *Publishing options* for each content type that needs moderation.

Often, one is required to review and edit content before it is published. So, you need to keep track of the state of a document beyond merely whether it is published or not. When authors enter content, it will be in the draft state. The authors may complete the entry over several sessions. Once they are satisfied, they should change the state of the content to *Needs Review*. The reviewer may approve the content as-is, or after editing it, and push it to the *Published* state. In case the reviewers are not satisfied, they may put it back in the draft state.

These are the default states in the Workbench Moderation module. You may wish to add a *Reviewed*